Finnish officer were in a vehicle on road to Damascus, hit a land mine, all dead.

Sept. 27

Most of my day spent on homework for press conference tomorrow night. It should be free wheeling what with Lebanon and all. Yom Kippur will be over tomorrow. Our troops will probably go ashore Wednesday.

Sept. 28

Cap W. signed order for Marines to go ashore Wednesday a.m. Israelis will withdraw to south of the airport; Marines will be stationed at the airport. . . . Spent afternoon getting ready for press conference. Have just had it and made it through okay. Everyone says "best yet." My favorite answer was to Sam D. [Donaldson] who asked if I didn't think I had done something to do with our economic problems, which I'd been laying on the Dems over the past year. I said: "Oh, my yes, I share the responsibility—I was a Democrat for years."

Sept. 30

The Congress got the 218 names on the discharge petition and brought the "balanced budget" amendment to the floor. I went up to the Capitol to speak to them . . . a sad day, though, one of our Marines in Beirut, Lebanon, stepped on a mine or a part of a cluster bomb that hadn't exploded. We're still getting the details. One, a corporal, named Reagan was killed, the others wounded.

The terrorism and killings continued through the early fall of 1982. Nevertheless, we had a few reasons to be optimistic about the Middle East. Following the murder of